



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times
DAVID CARPENTER was sentenced to death for several slayings in Northern California from 1979 to 1981. Carpenter said he now gets a hot breakfast every day and enjoys much more time on the yard.

IN CALIFORNIA, LIFE AFTER DEATH ROW

By age 46, Bob Williams had spent more than half his life in isolation, waiting to die on San Quentin's death row. Williams was 18 when he raped and murdered 40-year-old Mary Breck at her Kern County home in October 1994. The day before, he had broken into Breck's home and stolen her credit cards. He returned — initially with the intention of giving the items back, he said — but instead brutally assaulted and strangled Breck, leaving her gasping for air in her bedroom before he went back to finish the killing. He was convicted of first-degree murder and sentenced to death. By that point, Williams had spent his youth cycling through ju-

Years after the moratorium on executions, inmates say they have a bittersweet new lease on life

By Hannah Wiley
REPORTING FROM SAN FRANCISCO

venile hall and foster homes. Sad as it may sound, he said, getting sent to San Quentin “was the best thing that ever happened to me.” “I went to prison with the idea of, No. 1, finding God, and if I could find God, find some kind of forgiveness if it was available,” Williams said. On death row, he built a life amid the dank cells of concrete and iron stacked five stories high. He soaked up books on philosophy and spirituality, finding solace in the poem “Invictus.” He had come to terms with his death sentence, the prospect of lethal injection always looming, when due to political churns out of his control, San Quentin's death row was itself de- [See **Death row**, A7]

Outrage grows over killing of activist

Indigenous advocate and husband among victims of violence in Mexico's Oaxaca state.

By Patrick J. McDonnell and Cecilia Sánchez Vidal

MEXICO CITY — She was a fearless advocate for her Mixe Indigenous community, a lawyer and mother who denounced violence against women — while also exposing misogynist chat groups among politicians in Mexico's southern Oaxaca state. Her high-profile activism led to death threats, colleagues say, but Sandra Estéfana Domínguez Martínez [See **Activist**, A4]

Tariffs threaten trucking jobs

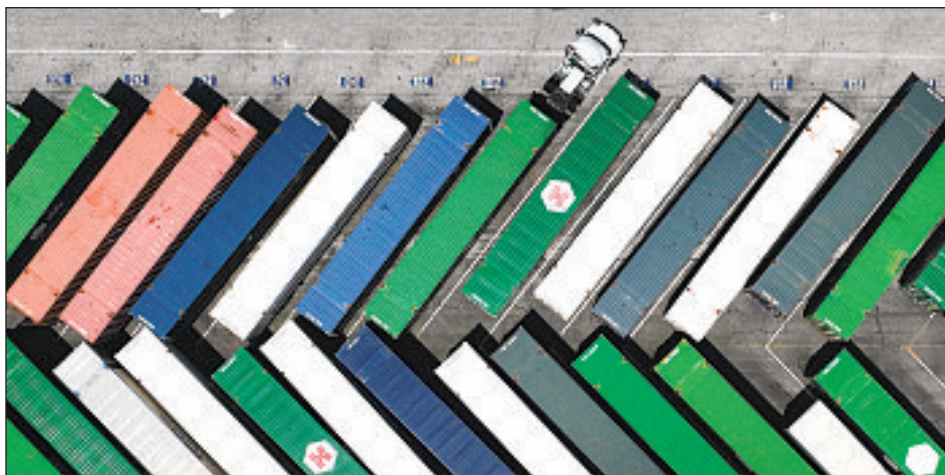
Shipping slowdown putting port workers at risk

By Caroline Petrow-Cohen and James Rainey

Amid a wave of unprecedented tariffs, anxiety is running high for truck drivers like Helen, who makes her living delivering cargo containers from the Los Angeles

and Long Beach harbors to warehouses and other customers around Southern California. After a strong start to the year, the number of jobs has started to slip in recent days and truck drivers have heard reports predicting a sharp decline in incoming cargo for May and June.

Helen, a 38-year-old mother of three, said her family has to stretch to make ends meet even under normal conditions. “There's real concern that we're going to be struggling,” said Helen, a Downey resident who declined to give her last name for fear [See **Truckers**, A9]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times
THE PORTS of Los Angeles and Long Beach support over 165,000 jobs. A projected 35% drop in cargo ship arrivals over two weeks could wipe out thousands.

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

After L.A. fires, testing soil for toxicity yielded alarming results

When FEMA failed to gather data on hazardous substances in burn areas, The Times found high levels of lead and other heavy metals

By Tony Briscoe, Noah Haggerty and Hayley Smith

On the heels of the Eaton and Palisades fires, among the most destructive urban wildfires in U.S. history, federal and state disaster agencies have refused to pay for soil testing to ensure fire-related contamination no longer remains in thousands of now-empty dirt lots across Los Angeles County. Without this long-established precautionary measure, tens of thousands of wildfire survivors are poised to rebuild and eventually return home, not knowing if unhealthy levels of heavy metals are hidden in the soil on their properties. That leaves homeowners with a daunting choice: pay for testing and potentially additional soil removal themselves, or live with the possibility of lingering contamination.

How concerned should homeowners be? The Los Angeles Times set out to answer that question by launching its own soil-testing initiative, modeled after the state's sampling methodology used in previous wildfires. Journalists fanned out across Altadena and Pacific Palisades to obtain soil samples from 20 properties cleared by federal cleanup crews and 20 homes that survived; the samples were transported to a state-certified laboratory where they were tested for 17 toxic metals.

Two of the 10 Army Corps-remediated homesites in Altadena still had toxic heavy metals in excess of California standards for residential properties — including one where lead levels were more than three times higher than the state benchmark. The findings are the first evidence that — by skipping comprehensive soil sampling — federal contractors are leaving toxic contamination behind.

Testing also revealed elevated levels of arsenic, lead and mercury in the yards of three homes that survived the Eaton fire — although these homeowners did not have the benefit of a federal cleanup.

These results — along with historical data from previous fires — suggest that there could be more than a thousand ostensibly remediated properties still containing toxic substances in the regions ravaged by the fires in January.

Prolonged exposure to lead — a potent neurotoxin — raises the risk of irreversibly stunting cognitive development in children and inflicting serious kidney damage in adults. Mercury is a neurotoxin and can impair [See **Soil**, A10]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times
THE ARMY CORPS of Engineers clears debris from a burned house on West Palm Street in Altadena.

Can Apple make it big in Hollywood?

Even with streaming hits like ‘Severance,’ the tech giant still has some room to grow.

By Wendy Lee

In the first episode of the Apple TV+ show “The Studio,” Oscar-winning director Martin Scorsese sells his script to the fictional Continental Studios, only to be told later by a studio chief played by Seth Rogen that the project, about Jones-town, has been killed.

Instead, the company is fast-tracking a soulless brand-based cash grab: a Kool-Aid movie.

“Just give me back my movie and let me go sell it to f— Apple, the way I should have done it in the first place,” a despairing Scorsese says. The line could practically be an ad for how Apple TV+, the Cupertino tech giant's streaming service, has positioned itself as a creative haven for filmmakers trying to sell bold, original ideas. The service, which was introduced in 2019 with a splashy event featuring Oprah Winfrey and Steven Spielberg, found success with comedy shows such as “Ted Lasso” and 2022 best picture Academy Award winner “CODA.” But the question hanging [See **Apple**, A9]

No U.S. troops, Mexico says
President Claudia Sheinbaum says Trump wanted to send the Army to fight drug cartels. **WORLD, A4**

Buffett to retire at end of the year
Billionaire investor shocks shareholders by announcing intentions after blasting Trump's tariff policy. **NATION, A6**

Half a century of telling stories
Steve Lopez wouldn't change a thing, even if it feels like he's riding on the Hindenburg. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
A shower in spots. L.A. Basin: 66/56. **B9**



Every story. Every section. Every feature.
Subscribers get unlimited app access. Download now.

